compassion by the horrors of war, prepared to return home following the atomic bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

I was looking out at the sprawling city, imagining unseen lives playing out beneath me, when there was a knock on the door. Jimmy and Swanny burst in and looked at me, red-eyed, with a mixture of amusement and alarm. ‘Thank fuck you guys have turned up,’ I said. We were in a dry state, Gujarat, with a two-phase, three-month, four-Test tour stretching ahead of us. A beer would have gone down well.

In such circumstances there is no alternative to throwing everything at it. Kevin and I each scored centuries in the warm-up matches, but we were hammered by nine wickets in the first Test. Sehwag got a quick hundred, Cheteshwar Pujara announced himself with an unbeaten 206, and we followed on, trailing by 330.

We had done a lot of work on playing spin in the nets. The skill lies in not getting caught playing half forward, half back. It is the most mentally challenging aspect of the game and hitting without consequence in practice can be deceptive. A delicate balance needs to be struck. We had spoken of being positive, putting the pressure on the bowler, and trained assertively.

When the pressure is on, aggression can be self-destructive. Training in the nets, with lots of sweeps and big shots, can sometimes disguise a batsman’s deeper lack of trust in his defensive technique. Ian Bell, for instance, is accomplished facing spin; he ran down the wicket to Pragyan Ojha, the slow left-armer, didn’t get to the pitch of the delivery and was out first ball. That signalled a bit of a scrambled mind.

There were mitigating circumstances, because he was preparing to return home for the premature birth of his son Joseph. Maybe we were over ambitious, in seeking to put the pressure back on the Indian spinners. As captain, I had to lead by example. I batted for 556 minutes for 176 in the second innings, sweeping consistently and choosing my moments to use my feet. We avoided an innings defeat and at one stage, when Matty Prior was similarly resistant, I sensed we had them worried.

Batting in India is a mental challenge. The first twenty or thirty balls are very hard work. Everyone is around you, chatting away. Bowlers specialize in pinning you down. It doesn’t take long for the Gimp to ask, ‘How are you going to score a run here?’ You must be at ease having fielders clustered around the bat. You must learn to manipulate the field, to milk runs carefully but decisively. It is a case of low risk, high reward.